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Choosing an Operation

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Choosing an Operation

Choosing an Operation

Addition

sum

total

plus

in all

combined

altogether

Subtraction

difference

minus

how many more

how many less

how much left

Multiplication

product

times

doubled

per

each

Division

quotient

divided

shared equally

equal parts

each

These word clues are only a guide. Addition and subtraction are opposite operations, so you will sometimes see addition words in a subtraction problem. The same is true for multiplication and division. As you read, you should also pay attention to any numbers that are missing from the problem.

Example

Hide

A lamp is placed on a table. The combined height of the lamp and the table is 54 inches. The table is 36 inches tall. What operation should you use to find the height of the lamp?

Step 1

Look for words that suggest a certain operation.

Combined

is an addition word. The height of the lamp plus the height of the table is the combined height.

Step 2

What information is missing?

Lamp height

+

Table height

=

Combined height

?

36

54

Step 3

Choose an operation.

Since you already know the combined height, addition doesn't make sense. You should choose the opposite operation: subtraction.

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^

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=

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Lesson 3: Solving Problems

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